

As CPI(M) cadres and tribals clash over land in a sleepy hamlet in the state's Munnar hills, there are fears that Kerala may witness another Nandigram

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

The original architects of land reforms in the country are now turning out to be one of the finest practitioners of land grab. One of the most picturesque spots in God's own country is witnessing an ugly showdown between a group of tribals and CPI(M) cadres, triggered by a heated dispute over land. Chinnakanal village near Munnar, a hill station, is now being referred to as a Nandigram-in-the-making. The disputed land is much sought after by real estate sharks and the hotel industry, thanks to the tourism boom. It was in the tea and cardamom plantations-filled Munnar hills—once a summer retreat of British colonial officials—where the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government had recently held a massive drive against encroachers demolishing scores of unauthorised resorts.

Since November 23, more than 150 tribal families including women and children have been laying siege to parts of 1,500 acres in Chinnakanal, which had been leased out to Hindustan Newsprint Limited, a central public sector undertaking. The siege is a part of the landless tribals' struggle against the failure of the state government to fulfill its four-year-old promise of giving them land even after being issued title deeds.

But on November 26, scores of local CPI(M) workers entered and fenced the area claiming it as their own and planted red flags all around. "CPI(M) workers terrorised and drove us off so that they could sell the high-value land to the resort lobby," says Valsa, a leader of the Adivasi Punaradhivasa Samrakshana Samithi (APSS), which is leading the struggle. Following CPI(M), local Congress and CPI workers too entered the area and marked their own "liberated zones", pushing the tribals to the margins. As they withdrew without

RED ALERT: Tribals seeking protection from Marxist encroachers (top); Chandy (centre) plays messiah



REFORMERS TURN GRABBERS

